

Types of Interviews Prep

	Prep/Materials Considerations
In-person	
Telephone	
Panel	
Remote/ Videoconference	

Interview Guide

What are your strengths and weaknesses?

This is trying to get an honest sense of your skill set and is one of the most common questions. For strengths, give 2 or 3 of your key strengths and ensure they are relevant to the role and importantly, that you can back them up with examples. For weaknesses, be honest and provide a weakness you know is not a central competency required for the role. This shows self-awareness and gives you an opportunity to explain you are looking to address your weakness.

DO

- Highlight 2 or 3 strengths that are relevant to the role
- Back them up with facts, statistics and plenty of examples
- Give a real weakness that is not a key skill for the role
- Explain, using examples, what you are doing to address your weakness

DON'T

- List too many strengths; it looks unfocussed and unrealistic
- Give a weakness that is really a strength e.g. 'I am a perfectionist', will annoy a recruiter
- Give weaknesses in areas that are essential to the job, such as, 'being disorganized' if you're applying to be a project manager
- Deny that you have any weaknesses

What interests you about our company?

This question requires an enthusiastic response demonstrating what you know about the employer and why you are well suited. A short response stating that the company is global, or a big brand is a poor answer, demonstrating little thought. The interviewer wants to see if you understand what the company does, what their reputation is and culturally what type of employer they are. Be careful when discussing career progression, since the employer usually wants someone focused on the immediate role. Most of all they will want to feel your enthusiasm for the business.

DO

- Know all your basic facts on the business, product lines, customers, culture etc.
- Be enthusiastic; the employer wants you to have deliberately picked them
- Drill down on what you want and how this can match your short- and long-term ambitions

DON'T

- Have a short, bland, answer that makes generalist statements
- Talk too much about career progression, since the employer wants you for an immediate need
- Base your answer on basic facts e.g., global or big brand

Tell me why you want this job

This is your opportunity to show your research, passion and desire. An employer is looking for you to show a good understanding of the organization and role requirements, matching your ambitions and passion to the role and identifying clearly why you should be considered. A generic answer here must be avoided (e.g., "because you are a big brand or company") - the interviewer is really asking for you to impress them with your knowledge and effort you put into preparing for the interview. They want to know why you applied.

DO

- Keep your answers relevant and focused on either the company or role specifics
- Research the role and organization fully and highlight the specific things that excite you the most; ensure you demonstrate how your skills will apply to the role
- Be passionate and discuss your ambitions; talk about how this role will motivate you

DON'T

- Discuss irrelevant skills or interests that are not specifically part of the role being discussed
- Give a bland answer e.g., about the company being big, reputable, dynamic
- Talk about factors such as money, training, holiday allowance or the role being a steppingstone

Tell me about yourself

This is one of the most commonly used interview questions. The interviewer asks this to get a rounded sense of you as a person, and how you might fit within the team/organization and is looking for your elevator pitch.

The question seems informal, but don't drop your guard and shift into ramble mode. Your interviewer is not looking for a 10-minute dissertation here. Instead, offer a focused sentence or two that sets the stage for further discussion and highlights your key skills, attitudes and personal objectives.

DO

- Mention impressive achievements early on, before there's a risk that they've tuned out
- Include enough information to give a rounded sense of you as a person; talk about you personally as well as professionally
- Give them 'your synopsis about you' answer, specifically your Unique Selling Proposition i.e., what makes you unique and suitable for the role

DON'T

- Ramble; keep things to a brief couple of minutes
- Assume the interviewer knows your background from your CV, they may have never read it
- Forget to research your interviewer; provided it's not done blatantly; this is an ideal opportunity to mention anything you have in common

What unique qualities and abilities will you bring to this job?

Employers ask this to draw out the key skills you offer. It is important to be honest, not just to say what you think they want to hear. Give examples and be sure to support with evidence.

Focus on why these make you suitable for the role. Examples can come from outside the working environment; e.g., playing as part of a football team may involve good communication, teamwork and leadership responsibilities. The question is asking for your elevator pitch. You will need to be different to the average candidate, so do not re-gurgitation the job specification.

DO

- Give genuine key skills which you are able to support with evidence
- Discuss how these key skills would be put to good use within the role
- Ask questions about the skills needed, this will turn the question into a natural conversation

DON'T

- Focus on skills which you have little experience of - you will be found out
- Offer skills which are irrelevant to the role. Provide a long list - employers are looking for a focused answer and less is more!

What are your salary expectations for this role?

For many positions this is a typical question. Ensure you are realistic and honest about your salary expectation, not doing so will blow your credibility. Just because you earned X at your last job, it doesn't mean the position you are applying for will pay at the same rate. Take time to research salaries, find out what similar positions pay, and be able to justify what you want. It is often better to NOT reveal numbers unless pressed. Instead talk about market rate and if you quote a bracket of pay, expect to be offered the bottom of the bracket.

DO

- Be honest about what you need
- Justify why you are looking for a certain salary
- Discuss other job offers you may have in a non-threatening way

DON'T

- Worry about raising the topic of pay in an interview
- Be aggressive or heavy-handed
- Rely on industry benchmarks, there is no 'standard' for pay

What's the biggest challenge you have faced?

Everybody can do a good job when things go well, it's much harder when there is a challenge, hence this question. The interviewer will want to hear about something recent, you will need to be honest (stock answers here are very dull and transparent), and they will primarily be interested in the process you went through to overcome the challenge as opposed to the outcome itself.

DO

- Use a recent example that you can talk confidently about
- Focus on the process to overcome the challenge
- Make it work-related, and ideally matching an element of the job spec you are applying for

DON'T

- Give a stock answer, it will be very transparent and dull
- Focus on anything overtly negative, if you have to make sure it was some time ago
- Talk top level e.g., 'the company was failing?', unless you were the key person addressing the issue

Why should we hire you?

This is asking for your elevator pitch, and the response needs to be specific to the role and company. A good approach is to use a few words to explain who you are, the skills you bring and what you are looking for, all in the context of the role. After showing a clear understanding of what is required to succeed in the role, focus on what differentiates you. Use examples of previous achievements that are relevant for the role, and of equal importance, show a real enthusiasm for the company - make it sound as if you carefully selected them.

DO

- Be engaged and show that you are passionate about the role, the company and its products
- Be confident and show your personality
- Leave the employer with a short elevator pitch rather than bland, 'stock' phrases they hear from most candidates

DON'T

- Be arrogant or exaggerate what you are likely to bring
- Expect qualifications to be enough to get you the job
- Talk for more than 2 minutes; this is your opportunity to quickly make your case

Give an example of when you've overcome a problem at work

This question is designed to uncover how you identified a problem at work, and more importantly how you approached it and overcame any challenges. The employer is interested in day-to-day issues within your control which you may have faced and how you identified and implemented a solution. Try, where possible, to pick a relatively recent example from your work experience.

DO

- Identify issues which are within your control
- Offer a clear description of the various solutions you may have considered, which one you chose, how you implemented it and as a result what was the outcome achieved
- Talk about what you learned and how this has helped you since then in your career

DON'T

- Address issues that are system related or of a nature which you are unable to overcome
- Identify personal issues you may have had with individual team members
- Use an example that's fundamental to the role you are applying for, particularly if it's a recent example

How do you build relationships with other members of your team?

The employer is looking for an understanding of your personality, how you will potentially interact within the office environment and for you to show some self-awareness in terms of how you feel you may fit in with the team in which the role is located and the company environment as a whole. For externally based roles this can also be an assessment of how you would be likely to interact with customers / suppliers / partners.

DO

- Consider not only how you may interact on a team level but also a company wide basis
- Be friendly, open and honest
- Give examples of relationships you have formed and how this aided performance

DON'T

- Expect the employer to understand your personality traits
- Be negative about previous relationships or team situations
- Be put off if you have no commercial experience, use examples from other team environments outside of work

Describe a situation where you had to adapt your working style

This question is designed to see just how adaptable you can be in your approach to business. The employer is looking for an individual to demonstrate, through examples, how they can be flexible, and how they understand that colleagues will have differing viewpoints and methods. Identify a scenario where you had to respond differently to meet different needs, identifying how you changed your approach throughout and what the outcome was.

DO

- Be armed with relevant examples and supporting evidence of what approach you used, how you adapted and what results it achieved
- Explain how, through past experience, you have learnt to be flexible depending on the requirement
- Show an understanding of how different approaches work in differing situations dependent upon the individual

DON'T

- Discuss situations with a negative outcome
- Forget to explain why you adapted your approach
- Forget to discuss the resulting outcome and what you learnt from past experiences

What management style suits your way of working?

This question identifies to the employer how you may fit within the organization. From a management perspective the employer is looking for the candidate to show that they can take on responsibility and be proactive without being high-maintenance and requiring constant guidance. This will allow them to assess how easy the transition would be if they employed you. Avoid talking about difficult situations with management elsewhere - the employer may worry similar issues could occur again.

DO

- Identify previous management styles you like and dislike, focusing on the reasons behind this
- Demonstrate that you are willing to be proactive and are capable of undertaking tasks off of your own initiative
- Talk openly about how you have been managed in the past and be honest about which approach worked best and why

DON'T

- Identify negative situations which, potentially, expose failure on your part rather than your manager
- Bad mouth previous bosses or organizations; never burn bridges
- Worry about interpretations of what a 'management style' is or specific terminology to use

What is your greatest achievement?

Being able to discuss your achievements in a structured manner and support with figures and facts is vital to selling yourself at interview. By having data on hand you can coherently display your potential and how you could add value to the role, team and organisation. Don't worry if your examples aren't earth-shattering, they just need to demonstrate you understand the impact of your activities. The interviewer will want to hear about how you achieved what you achieved - this is more interesting than the achievement itself.

DO

- Take examples of past achievements, the targets that were set and the results you achieved
- Be able to talk through how you achieved what you achieved in detail
- Relate your achievements to the role and discuss how your track record could add value to the team

DON'T

- Rely on the achievement alone to answer this question, the interviewer needs to know how you did it
- Discuss achievements that you cannot support with figures and dates
- Exaggerate or fabricate, you can easily be found out

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Tell me about a time when you failed to deliver

Honesty, recovery and learning are the order of the day. Everyone has, at some point, failed to deliver, and the interviewer wants to see that you're able to admit that, as well as demonstrate how you remedied the situation and learned and adapted from the experience. The ability to recognise your own failings and learn from them is an important quality, as long as you demonstrate the right attitude towards such experiences.

DO

- Choose an honest example, and provide a short summary of what happened
- Explain how you recovered from, and analysed, the situation after the event
- Describe what you learnt and how you now do things differently as a result

DON'T

- Phrase it as an obvious attempt to hide a strength; the interviewer will simply find this patronising
- Choose an example which led to a major failure; as much as the interviewer wants honesty, they still want confidence in your ability to perform
- Mention an example where you repeated an error and failed to learn from your mistakes

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Tell us about a time when you had to make a decision without all the facts

This is not a trick question. Within the business environment everyday decisions are made without the knowledge of the full facts. This question is designed to understand how you take on a balanced approach to the decision-making process, and how you use the information that is accessible to make judgements and an informed decision on a given situation. The employer wants to check you are able to make decisions without knowing all the detail, since there is rarely time to become a master of all - you need to be able to use your judgement and take measured risks.

DO

- Identify situations where a successful outcome was achieved
- Describe the situation including the information available, the nature of the decision, other people that were involved in the process and what the outcome was
- Explain how confident you are in this situation and talk about any experience that has helped you in the past

DON'T

- Use examples of decisions taken on topics outside of your knowledge area
- Fail to identify a situation where a decision could not be made without further research
- Pick an example essential to the role you are applying for where your decision was subsequently seen as incorrect

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What do you want to achieve in the first 3, 6 or 12 months

This is looking to understand your level of insight into the role, for evidence you have thought about what needs to be done and importantly, your approach. A good answer will be realistic, reference how you will learn and listen, plan, but also get on with things quickly once you start. Within the first 3 months you should also aim to achieve a goal you set out to reach. It's a good idea to talk about asking questions, networking internally and externally and achieving a quick win.

DO

- Identify your goals, and plan a strategy of how you expect to achieve these
- Be realistic; achieving most material things will take time so think carefully about what realistically you can achieve early in the first 2-3 months
- Have a longer-term plan to covering more ambitious things that can be achieved in the first year

DON'T

- Aim too low; aim high whilst maintaining a structure of how you expect to deliver results
- Make sweeping statements; it's easy to miss the complexities and priorities that exist when first entering an organisation
- Scrimp on the details; a bland answer about being punctual, meeting people, being polite etc... doesn't add much value

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Explain a task that you decided not to delegate

This question is designed so that the employer can identify an individual’s working style. Provide a tangible example describing why you chose to hold onto a specific task how you went about undertaking it and how you leveraged resources to achieve results. By doing this you are demonstrating to the employer your decision-making capabilities.

DO

- Be armed with real scenarios and the ability to explain them fully
- Show commitment and passion when describing why you decided not to delegate
- Explain the outcome and what you learnt form the process

DON'T

- Feel that all tasks should be delegated; in the right circumstances it is appropriate and can be beneficial to hold onto a particular task
- Don't use examples which ended in failure
- Forget to explain the reasons surrounding your decision and how you approached the situation

What do you think is the most important issue facing our business today?

This immediately shows your level of preparation for the interview. If asked this question, the interviewer expects to hear about a real issue facing the business or broader industry, or at least a credible attempt at something that could be an issue. If you get the issue wrong it's not a problem, it's more that you've been able to demonstrate commercial awareness by discussing a business issue.

DO

- Research press on the company site and industry trade websites
- Talk about a real issue i.e., relate to growth, cost, competition, legislation, social or economic points
- If unsure, engage in a conversation about the business by adopting a questioning approach

DON'T

- Talk too negatively, even if the industry or company is in decline
- Rely on a top-level answer about the general economy or similar
- Make sweeping statements

What questions do you have for me?

Interviews are often decided on the questions asked by a candidate. Having no questions is unprofessional. Having a few basic questions about the size of the company, number of offices or working hours is not much better. If you could have found out the answer prior to your interview, then you shouldn't be asking it. A good approach is to ask probing questions about the business, something you read in the press, or something you know about the competition. A great answer is to show your listening skills and construct questions as you go throughout the interview.

DO

- Take a conversational approach to the interview; ask questions throughout rather than waiting for the end
- Do your research before the interview and find topical issues or something interesting to ask about
- Where possible ask questions that refer to something said by the interviewer earlier in the interview

DON'T

- Ask bland questions e.g., holiday allowance or basic facts you should have known already
 - Leave all your questions until the end of the interview
 - Ask questions about money, keep this as a separate issue for later discussion
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- ✓ Why is the role vacant?
 - ✓ What would your expectations be of me in the first 30/60/90 days?
 - ✓ What are the top priorities of this role?
 - ✓ What are the top 3 biggest challenges for someone walking into this position?
 - ✓ What are you looking for in an ideal candidate?
 - ✓ What significant changes do you foresee in the industry? In the company? In the near future?
 - ✓ What attracted you to ABC Company?
 - ✓ What has made you stay at ABC Company?

Thank You Notes

EXAMPLE 1:

Dear XX

It was very enjoyable to speak with you about the XX position at the ABC Company. The job, as you presented it seems to be a very good match for my skills and interests and confirms my desire to work with you.

I am positive that my experience can make a measurable impact on your organization. I appreciate the time you took to interview me. I am very interested in working for you and look forward to hearing from you about this position.

Sincerely,

EXAMPLE 2:

Dear XX

Thank you for our interview this week; the time and insight you shared were very much appreciated. After our meeting, I am even more enthusiastic about the XX opportunity with your company.

I am confident that my experience and industry background would allow me to quickly make a contribution to your team.

I look forward to future discussions with (your company). Thanks again.

Regards,

EXAMPLE 3:

Dear XX

Thank you for the opportunity to discuss the XX position with your company. I believe my (A) and (B) skills, combined with significant (C) and (D) experience, would be an asset to your team. I look forward to future discussions to learn how I can contribute to your organization's goals.

Sincerely,

Interview Preparation Worksheet

Company Information

Position:	
Company Name:	
Location of interview	
Contact Person and Title:	
Email:	
Phone Number:	
Special Instructions:	

Company Research / Background

What is the company's mission/values/goals?
Who is on the Leadership Team (President/CEO, VP's)
When was the company founded?
Has the company undergone any expansions or mergers? Are any expansions or mergers anticipated?
What is the size of the company and how is it organized?
What are its products and/or services?
Where are offices/stores/plants located?
Has the company shown substantial and consistent growth? If so, when and to what extent?
Who are its major competitors?
How does the company rank in the industry?
Does the company have extensive employee turnover? What do employees like/dislike about working there?
To whom does the company sell or provide services?

Questions to ask in the interview

Position Analysis

Main Requirements for Positions	My Qualifications/Experience	Related Stories